

NORTHBRIDGE FC

Governance, Safeguarding & Data Protection Report 2024/25

For the year ended 30 June 2025

Bristol, England

Corporate Governance • Safeguarding • Privacy • Information Rights

Community • Ambition • Excellence

Fictional internal knowledge-base document. Northbridge FC, its governance records, safeguarding cases and data-protection matters are fictional. This document is not legal advice.

1. Executive Summary

Northbridge FC's governance framework is designed to provide clear accountability across the Board, executive management, football operations, safeguarding, legal, finance, people and data-protection functions.

Safeguarding is treated as a core Club responsibility rather than a specialist function operating in isolation. The Club maintains reporting, escalation, training and case-management arrangements for concerns involving children, young people and adults at risk.

Data protection is similarly embedded across the organization because Northbridge processes supporter, employee, player, academy, commercial and event-related personal information. For the 2024/25 reporting period, the Club's privacy framework is based on the UK GDPR and Data Protection Act 2018.

The ICO's accountability framework emphasizes that organizations remain responsible for demonstrating compliance and maintaining appropriate governance, documentation, data-protection-by-design measures, DPIAs, contracts and DPO arrangements where applicable. [\[cite\]turn0search9](#)

2024/25 governance overview

Area	Northbridge position
Board governance	Active / monitored
Board risk oversight	Active
Safeguarding leadership	Designated responsibility
Safeguarding reporting	Established escalation route
Data Protection Officer	Designated oversight
Privacy governance	Active / monitored
Data subject rights	Established process
Material unresolved governance issue	None reported
Material unresolved safeguarding issue	None reported
Material data breach	None reported

2. Governance Structure

Northbridge operates a three-level governance model: Board oversight, executive management and operational control functions. The model is designed so that material legal, financial, safeguarding and reputational risks can reach the appropriate decision-makers.

Governance body / role	Primary responsibility
Board of Directors	Strategic oversight and material risk
Board Chair	Board leadership and governance effectiveness
Chief Executive	Executive accountability
General Counsel / Legal	Legal and regulatory risk
Chief Financial Officer	Financial control and reporting

Governance body / role	Primary responsibility
Safeguarding Lead	Safeguarding policy and case escalation
Data Protection Officer	Privacy advice and oversight
People / HR	Employment and workforce governance
Football Operations	Football regulatory and sporting compliance

Three lines of accountability

- Operational teams own day-to-day compliance within their activities.
- Legal, finance, safeguarding, privacy and other specialist functions provide independent challenge and oversight.
- The Board and executive management receive escalated reporting on material risks and decisions.

3. Board & Corporate Governance

The Board is responsible for ensuring that the Club is managed in a manner consistent with its strategic objectives, legal obligations and risk appetite. It receives periodic reporting on financial performance, major projects, legal matters, safeguarding and other material risks.

Board oversight area	2024/25 focus
Financial position	Revenue, cash, debt and stadium investment
Football operations	Sporting performance and player investment
Commercial activity	Sponsorship and international growth
Stadium redevelopment	£32m capital program and project risk
Legal & compliance	Regulatory and contractual risk
Safeguarding	Policy, incidents and training
Data protection	Privacy risk and compliance
Reputation	Material stakeholder and conduct issues

Reserved matters

- Approval of major strategic investments.
- Material borrowing or financing arrangements.
- Major commercial commitments and sponsorship arrangements.
- Appointment or oversight of key control functions.
- Material litigation and regulatory matters.
- Significant safeguarding or reputational incidents.

4. Governance Risk Management

Risk category	Primary owner	Board visibility
Financial risk	Finance	High
Football regulatory risk	Football + Legal	High
Stadium project risk	Projects + Finance	High
Safeguarding risk	Safeguarding Lead	High
Data protection risk	DPO + Legal	High
Employment risk	People + Legal	Medium
Commercial contract risk	Commercial + Legal	Medium
Reputational risk	Executive + Legal	High

The Club's risk model distinguishes risks that require direct Board visibility from operational risks managed within departments. A material incident can be escalated immediately regardless of its normal reporting cycle.

5. Safeguarding Framework

Northbridge's safeguarding framework applies across first-team football, academy activities, women's football, community programs, stadium operations and relevant Club events.

The safeguarding model emphasizes prevention, safer recruitment, training, reporting, secure case management and appropriate escalation. The Club's processes are designed to support the welfare of children and young people and adults who may be at risk.

Safeguarding control	Northbridge approach
Designated lead	Named safeguarding responsibility
Safer recruitment	Role-appropriate checks before appointment
Training	Mandatory role-specific training
Reporting	Clear internal reporting route
Case management	Restricted access and documented actions
Escalation	Senior management / statutory / football authority as required
Whistleblowing	Protected route for concerns
Review	Periodic policy and incident review

The FA's safeguarding framework is an important part of English football governance, while data-protection law provides a framework for sharing information when necessary to protect children. The ICO states that data protection law does not prevent appropriate safeguarding information sharing and provides specific guidance for such situations. [\[cite\]](#)[turn0search3](#)[turn0search7](#)

Safeguarding reporting flow

Concern identified → immediate safety assessment → designated safeguarding lead → risk assessment → internal escalation → external referral where required → secure case record → follow-up and review.

6. Safer Recruitment & Personnel Controls

Northbridge uses enhanced recruitment controls for roles involving children or vulnerable people. Recruitment decisions are based on role requirements, appropriate checks, references, training and safeguarding suitability.

Control	Purpose
Role risk assessment	Identify safeguarding exposure
Identity verification	Confirm applicant identity
References	Assess suitability and history
DBS / relevant checks	Complete where legally and operationally required
Safeguarding training	Ensure understanding of responsibilities
Ongoing conduct review	Maintain standards after appointment

Safeguarding controls are applied proportionately to role and risk. The Club avoids treating a completed background check as a substitute for ongoing safeguarding responsibility.

7. Safeguarding Incidents & Escalation

Safeguarding information is treated as sensitive. Access is restricted to personnel who require it for their role, and information is shared externally only where there is an appropriate legal, safeguarding or regulatory basis.

Situation	Response
Immediate danger	Prioritize safety and emergency response
Concern without immediate danger	Record and refer to safeguarding lead
Allegation involving staff	Safeguarding + HR/legal assessment
Child safeguarding concern	Safeguarding assessment and appropriate referral
Regulatory concern	Relevant football authority engagement
Potential criminal matter	Consider appropriate statutory referral

The ICO's child-safeguarding guidance states that information can be shared where necessary to identify children at risk and protect them from harm, while emphasizing lawful basis, proportionate sharing, security and appropriate policies. [\[cite=turn0search3\]](#)

8. Data Protection Governance

Northbridge processes personal data across ticketing, membership, retail, digital platforms, employment, player management, academy activities, commercial relationships and safeguarding.

Data function	Northbridge control
Data Protection Officer	Independent privacy advice and oversight
Privacy notices	Purpose and rights transparency
Records of processing	Document material processing activities
Lawful basis	Identified before processing
Processor management	Contracts and due diligence
Data retention	Retention schedules and deletion controls
Security	Technical and organizational safeguards
Rights requests	Central intake and response process

The ICO states that organizations must identify and document a lawful basis before processing personal information and include the relevant basis and purposes in privacy information. [\[cite=turn0search0\]](#)

9. Principal Data Categories

Data category	Examples	Sensitivity
Supporter data	Ticketing, membership, contact details	Medium
Commercial data	Partner contacts and business records	Medium
Employee data	HR and payroll information	High

Data category	Examples	Sensitivity
Player data	Contracts, performance and personal records	High
Academy data	Youth records and welfare information	High
Safeguarding data	Concerns, case records and referrals	Very high
Payment data	Transaction and billing information	High
Digital data	Accounts, preferences and usage information	Medium

10. Lawful Basis & Privacy Controls

Northbridge does not assume that consent is the default lawful basis for all processing. The appropriate basis depends on the purpose, relationship and type of information involved.

Processing example	Potential legal basis / control
Employment administration	Contract / legal obligation as applicable
Ticketing contract	Contract
Regulatory reporting	Legal obligation / applicable regulatory requirement
Marketing	Consent or legitimate interests depending on activity
Safeguarding	Appropriate lawful basis and safeguarding conditions
Fraud / crime prevention	Relevant lawful basis and additional conditions
Data sharing	Documented lawful basis and necessity assessment

The ICO's lawful-basis guidance identifies seven bases and emphasizes that the correct basis must be determined before processing and documented. Special-category and criminal-offence data require additional conditions where applicable. [\[cite\]turn0search0](#)

11. Data Sharing & Information Governance

Northbridge shares personal information with service providers, football authorities, professional advisers, safeguarding partners and other organizations where appropriate. The Club's approach is to determine necessity, purpose, lawful basis, recipient, security and retention before sharing.

Data-sharing control	Required action
Purpose	Define why information is being shared
Necessity	Share only what is needed
Lawful basis	Identify and document before sharing
Recipient	Confirm appropriate organization / role
Security	Use appropriate transfer and access controls
Transparency	Consider privacy information and individual rights
Agreement	Use a data-sharing agreement where appropriate
Retention	Define how long the recipient needs the data

The ICO's data-sharing code emphasizes fairness, transparency, proportionality and lawful basis. It also provides tools for routine and one-off sharing. [cite]turn0search4[turn0search6]

12. Children, Academy Data & Safeguarding Privacy

Academy and youth-program information requires additional care because children may be less able to understand or control how their personal information is used.

The Club uses role-based access, limited disclosure and enhanced safeguarding controls for youth records. Where information must be shared to protect a child, the Club prioritizes the child's welfare while ensuring that the sharing is necessary, proportionate and properly documented.

The ICO advises that when sharing children's personal data, organizations should take extra care, consider the child's best interests and build appropriate safeguards into the data-sharing process. [cite]turn0search10]

13. Data Subject Rights

Right / request	Northbridge process
Access	Identity verification, search and response
Rectification	Review and correct inaccurate data
Erasure	Assess request against applicable exceptions
Restriction	Restrict processing where conditions apply
Objection	Assess purpose and lawful basis
Portability	Provide qualifying data in appropriate format
Automated decision rights	Assess applicable processing

Requests are routed through the privacy function and assessed according to the applicable legal requirements. The Club maintains records of requests, decisions and response dates.

14. Data Breach Management

Northbridge maintains an incident-response process for suspected personal-data breaches. The objective is to contain the incident, assess risk, preserve evidence, determine notification requirements and prevent recurrence.

Stage	Action
Detection	Report suspected incident immediately
Containment	Limit unauthorized access or disclosure
Assessment	Determine data, people, severity and likelihood
Legal / DPO review	Assess regulatory and contractual duties
Notification	Notify regulator / individuals where legally required
Remediation	Correct vulnerability and reduce recurrence
Lessons learned	Update controls and training

The Club treats breach reporting as a risk-based legal decision rather than an automatic notification exercise. Relevant legal and regulatory time limits are assessed from the facts of each incident.

15. Privacy by Design & DPIAs

Northbridge uses privacy-by-design principles when introducing material systems or processing activities. A Data Protection Impact Assessment is considered where processing is likely to result in a high risk to individuals.

Project example	Privacy review
New supporter platform	DPIA screening
Large-scale analytics	DPIA screening
Biometric / access technology	Enhanced privacy assessment

Project example	Privacy review
New safeguarding database	Enhanced assessment
Major third-party processor	Processor and security review
International data activity	Transfer and jurisdiction review

The ICO's accountability and governance guidance specifically addresses data-protection-by-design, DPIAs, DPOs and contracts as components of an accountable privacy program. [cite]turn0search9[

16. Governance, Safeguarding & Privacy Risk Register

Risk	Level	Control
Safeguarding failure	Key	Training, reporting and escalation
Child data mishandling	Key	Restricted access and privacy controls
Material data breach	Key	Security and incident response
Governance failure	Key	Board oversight and reserved matters
Unlawful data sharing	Key	Lawful-basis and necessity assessment
Privacy request failure	Secondary	Central rights-management process
Reputational incident	Secondary	Executive escalation and communications

17. Governance & Compliance Outlook

Northbridge expects governance requirements to become more complex as the Club expands its commercial operations, international supporter base, European football participation and digital ecosystem.

- Maintain clear Board-level oversight of material legal, safeguarding and privacy risks.
- Strengthen safeguarding training and reporting culture.
- Improve data inventories and records of processing.
- Continue privacy-by-design review of new digital systems.
- Strengthen data-sharing agreements and third-party governance.
- Integrate safeguarding and privacy risk reporting into the wider Club risk framework.

18. Legal Analyst Questions

- How is Northbridge's governance structure organized?
- What responsibilities sit with the Board versus operational control functions?
- How is safeguarding governed across the Club?
- What happens when a safeguarding concern is reported?
- How are academy and child records protected?
- What data categories does Northbridge process?

- How does the Club determine the lawful basis for processing?
- When might Northbridge need a DPIA?
- How are personal-data breaches handled?
- How does Northbridge manage data-sharing requests?
- What rights can supporters, players and employees exercise over their personal data?
- What are the key governance, safeguarding and privacy risks?
- How does data protection interact with safeguarding?
- What are the governance priorities for the next reporting period?

Historical regulatory note

This document is framed as a 2024/25 Northbridge FC internal report. Its privacy framework therefore uses the UK GDPR and Data Protection Act 2018 as the reporting-period baseline. Current ICO guidance has since been updated in response to the Data (Use and Access) Act 2025; those later changes should not be retroactively treated as 2024/25 Northbridge facts. [cite[turn0search9[turn0search0]

The ICO sources used for the structure of this fictional document cover accountability, lawful basis, data sharing, children's data and safeguarding-related information sharing.

[cite[turn0search2[turn0search3[turn0search7]

All Northbridge governance structures, safeguarding records, incidents, policies and privacy matters are fictional. This document is a synthetic RAG knowledge-base source and is not legal advice.